

Reptiles and amphibians

Both snakes and lizards are tolerant of dry climates, and these reptiles are among the most common of desert animals. Amphibians are much more in danger of drying out, but a few species do appear on the desert surface, especially after rare bouts of rain.

Fringe-toed lizard

This lizard forages in sandy deserts. When the surface becomes too hot, it stands on two legs to help keep cool. Projections between its toes spread its weight and stop it from sinking into the sand.



Lizard can close its nostrils to prevent sand getting into its air passages.

Sand viper buries itself tail first.



Snake descends vertically into the sand.



Sand viper

The sand viper has perfected an efficient way of disappearing on desert dunes. It wriggles down into the loose sand, becoming buried within seconds. It does this to escape danger and to be ready to attack prey.



Water-holding frog

For months, this frog lies dormant underground in a waterproof cocoon. It emerges to feed and breed only after heavy rains, swelling its body with water before it returns into the soil.



Sandfish

The sandfish is a lizard that makes its home on desert sand dunes. It is named after the way it moves across and through the sand, pushing sideways with its flattened toes as if it were swimming. Like other small lizards, it hunts mainly for insects.



Gila monster

The Gila monster is a fearsome lizard. Large, with a venomous bite, it leaves its burrow at dawn to hunt rodents and raid birds' nests. Fat stored in its thick tail provides nourishment when prey is scarce.



Smooth scales



Yucca moth

The yucca moth of American deserts has evolved a close relationship with the yucca plant. The moth pollinates the plant; the yucca flowers give shelter to the moth larvae.



Desert cricket

An inhabitant of the deserts of India and Pakistan, the desert cricket can bury itself quickly in the sand. It digs a hole directly beneath itself with its star-shaped feet and sinks down.

Invertebrates

Few insects and other invertebrates can withstand the full force of the desert Sun. Those that can have an especially tough, waxy covering, or cuticle, that prevents them from drying out. Other invertebrates take shelter during the day.

White spots warn off predators.



Domino beetle

This domino beetle lives in the dry lands of northern Africa through to the Middle East. During the day, it hides under rocks and in holes made by other animals. At night, it emerges to hunt insects and other small prey.

Scorpion

Scorpions are among the hardest of desert invertebrates, able to tolerate strong sunshine though they normally hunt at night. Armed with strong claws and a lethal sting, they ambush foraging insects such as locusts, as well as spiders and other scorpions.

The venom of this scorpion is strong enough to kill a person.

The scorpion holds its prey in its large claws.



Plants

Only the hardiest of drought-resistant plants can survive all year in the desert. Among these are cacti and yuccas. Seeds of more fragile plants lie dormant in the soil. After a rainburst, they sprout and flower before the moisture evaporates.



Little snapdragon vine

Rains in the Mexican desert bring the seeds of snapdragon vines to life. The vines quickly grow, trailing over the soil and curling around other plants. They flower and set new seed before they die as the conditions get dry again.

Each leaf grows up to 2 m (6.5 ft) long.

Seeds develop after the vine's flower has been pollinated by insects.

A welwitschia plant may live for 1,000 years or more.



Leaves usually split into several strips.

Desert holly

Some desert plants, such as the desert holly, have dusty-looking leaves. Salt secreted through leaf pores forms a fine whitish powder. This reflects some of the Sun's rays, helping to keep the leaves cool and preventing excessive evaporation of moisture.



Welwitschia

This plant has two ribbon-like leaves that trail across the sand. Each leaf has millions of pores that extract moisture from the sea fogs that sweep the Namib Desert in Africa.



Cacti

Many different kinds of cactus grow in American deserts. All store water in their green swollen stems. They do not have leaves, and this prevents excess moisture loss. Sharp spines deter animals from biting the succulent stems.

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